Western attempts towards reconciliation with the Taliban. Though the coalition military umbrella offered India a security blanket to reengage with Afghanistan, and helped bringing down the levels of infiltrations in Indian-administered Kashmir, there was little in common between Indian and American perceptions about Afghanistan. Beginning with the ISAF's efforts to rebuild Afghanistan (an endeavour that had full support of US president Bush especially after 9/11), and Washington's decision to invade Iraq in 2003, to the reconciliation drive launched by London in 2010, India had political and conceptual differences on nearly all these issues. Focused on defeating Al Qaeda, the US had little intention to undertake serious nation building in Afghanistan. The 'Light Footprint' model or 'Nation-Building Lite', as it was called, required few boots on the ground and even less money.[8] In the first donor's conference in Tokyo, for instance, Washington pledged a meager US$ 290 million in aid and was outbid by Iran that pledged US$ 540 million.[9] In February 2002, the then US secretary of defence Donald Rumsfeld stated that a large peacekeeping force outside Kabul was not necessary. Soon after, in 2003 the US declared war on Iraq and shifted most of its resources to the Middle East.

Such neglect of Afghanistan was dangerous from an Indian perspective. It meant that the US involvement in Afghanistan would be marred by failures and would eventually pave the way for Pakistan to influence domestic Afghan politics. The situation evolved along expected lines. Within a short span, the Taliban had unleashed a potent insurgency against the coalition forces. In 2006, despite building pressure to counter the Taliban, then US secretary of defense Robert Gates (Rumsfeld's successor) asserted that the NATO/ISAF would not conduct long-term counter-insurgency (COIN) operations in Afghanistan. The new US President Barack Obama ordered a troop surge in 2008 and began looking for a way out. The US decision to withdraw by 2014 was formally announced in 2011.[10] According to a senior Western official posted in Kabul in 2008, 'the idea of the surge was not really to fight an insurgency, but to put pressure on the Taliban and secure a honourable exit'.[11] India was unimpressed. Even staunch partisans, to whom alignment with the US seemed like the 'correct' response in the shadow of 9/11, grew wary.[12] Former Afghan deputy foreign minister Jawed Ludin ruefully recalled that 'one of our [Afghanistan's] regrets has always been